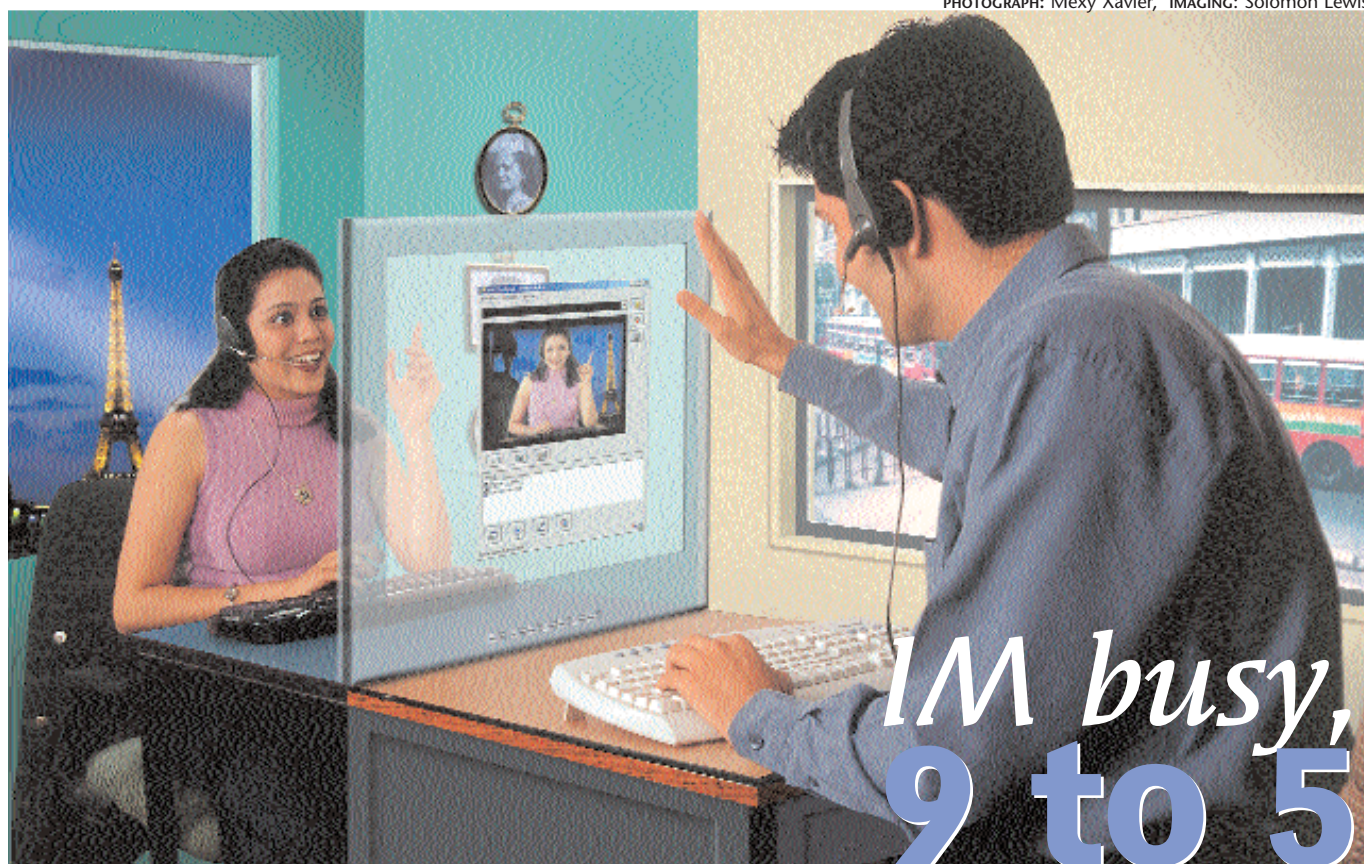




Instant Messengers are not just for idle chatter, they can also benefit your business!

3:30 am. Your eyes meet the piercing gaze of the boss. You need to come up with that one liner ASAP, or waltz your job away. An entire day's brainstorming with your freelancing friend has yielded nothing... And then, ping! He screams a bright idea to your desktop. Eureka! It's a clincher! The boss's gaze gets friendlier, and you, in turn, gratuitously doff your hat to your friend... sitting back in the US, and of course, Yahoo! Messenger.

Instant Messengers have been around for quite a while. A few years ago, someone came up with this brilliant idea that has made it easy for all surfers to communicate directly with each other. Today, a huge chunk of online traffic is peer-to-peer, i.e. directly from one person's computer, to another person's computer. And we are not just talking about the Napster

clones either. A lot of the traffic is actual communication between real people—be it sharing of ideas, conducting business, or simply staying in touch with mom and dad back home. It's all happening online, and in real time.

The first tool—I Seek You (ICQ)—was developed by three Israelis, in late 1996. Its core functionality is instant messaging (IM), that refers to short text messages, delivered 'instantly' to a user online. Simply download the software, install it, register, add your friends to your contact list, and exchange instant messages with them, whenever any of them come online.

Metcalfe's law states that the value of a network grows as the square of the number of users. Imagine if only you and three other people in the world had phones. This would make your phone practically useless. But as the network grows, so does its value. But because all your friends have phones, you can communicate with the person you want to, when you want to. Today IM is a rage, its users having grown to several millions worldwide—faster than fax, e-mail, cell phones, or the Web. So,

the more of your friends and contacts that are online, the more useful the communication tool becomes. Unfortunately, there are several competing standards for communication. Currently, each IM user can only communicate with users of the same IM. This effectively reduces the number of people, and consequently, the value of your network. For a casual user, the choice of network depends largely upon how many of your friends and contacts are on a particular network. Some users, are happy running multiple IM clients to have maximum connectivity.

Users see the benefits of IM every day, and large companies have been looking to gain a foothold over the IM market for some time now. There are four big players in the IM space today—ICQ, Microsoft's MSN Messenger, Yahoo! Messenger, and AOL's Instant Messenger (AIM). MSN grew in popularity because of its simplicity and its tight integration with its ubiquitous Hotmail service. Similarly, Yahoo! and AIM have capitalised on their strong user base, to enhance their popularity. Groups of friends, or office departments, generally like to use

Find it on the Mindware CD

ICQ Pro 2003a

Yahoo! Messenger 5.6

MSN Messenger 5.0

Trillian 0.74

